Topic 5 — Revolt of 1857

Sources baked in: NCERT Themes III, Spectrum, Bipan Chandra, Savarkar, Ghatnachakra Purvalokan (Revolt of 1857), UPPCS Prelims 2018–2025 **Weight:** ★★★ — centre↔leader, place↔date, Bareilly, Kunwar/Lakshmibai, Awadh 1856, historiography labels, Peel army **Last verified:** September 2026 gap audit — centre CCR confirmed; civilian vs sepoy + partial success + Acts-after cards filled; Extra Drill present (no invented mega banks) **Current Affairs:** N/A (historical)

5.0 One clear picture — why 1857 rose and fell

Stage	Fact
Long causes	Lapse, Awadh 1856 (अवध), revenue, mission fear, sepoy grievances
Spark	Greased cartridge + Barrackpore / Meerut
Spread	Delhi symbol → UP–Bihar–Central India belt
Suppression	Loyal princes, Punjab/South quiet, telegraph/rail, no central command
Aftermath	**GOI Act 1858**, Queen's Proclamation, army reorganised, Crown rule

Why Punjab and the South stayed mostly loyal / quiet

- Recent Sikh wars left Punjab under tight Company control with Sikh chiefs allied to the British.
- Madras and Bombay armies had different recruitment patterns and fewer high-caste Bengal Army grievances.
- Many southern princes and Hyderabad backed the Company.
- The revolt's core was the **Bengal Army** belt of North India, not a pan-India plan.

Nature of the revolt (historiography — keep short)

- British writers stressed a **sepoy mutiny** (**John Lawrence**, **Seeley**).
- **Sir James Outram** and **W. Taylor** called it a **Hindu–Muslim conspiracy** (Muslim plot using Hindu grievances).
- **T.R. Holmes** framed it as a clash of **civilisation and barbarism**.
- **V.D. Savarkar (1909)** called it the **First War of Independence**.
- **R.C. Majumdar** (*The Sepoy Mutiny and the Revolt of 1857*, **1957**) wrote that it was **neither first, nor national, nor a war of independence**.
- **S.N. Sen** (*Eighteen Fifty-Seven*, **1957**) was the **official** historian of the freedom struggle for the Government of India; with Majumdar he also treated mid-19th-century nationalism as still **embryonic**.
- **Sir Syed Ahmad Khan** analysed causes in *Asbab-e-Baghawat-e-Hind* (**1859**).

- Later historians stress peasant, taluqdar and regional strands as well; still keep **centres, leaders, dates and consequences** clear.

> **Logic:** Labels matter less than **Meerut 10 May**, centre↔leader matches, and **1858 Crown** — but Savarkar vs Majumdar vs Outram–Taylor (आउटराम) remain high-yield confused pairs.

5.1 Revolt of 1857

- The Revolt of 1857 was a widespread uprising against **East India Company** rule. It lasted from **1857 to 1858**.
- It started among **sepoys** (Indian soldiers) and then spread to peasants, taluqdars, artisans and displaced Indian rulers.
- The strongest area was **North and Central India**, especially present-day **Uttar Pradesh** (उत्तर प्रदेश).
- The British called it a **Sepoy Mutiny**. Later nationalist writers called it the **First War of Independence**.
- **V.D. Savarkar** used that nationalist name in his book *The Indian War of Independence* (इंडियन वॉर ऑफ इंडिपेंडेंस) (**1909**).
- Popular symbols of the rising were the **lotus** and **chapatis**.
- It was **not** a war of the whole of India. **Punjab, Madras, Bombay, Hyderabad** and most of **South India** stayed quiet or helped the British.
- There was **no single national command** and no modern political party (राजनीतिक दल) behind it.

> **Logic:** The revolt did **not** begin at Delhi. The mass outbreak was at **Meerut on 10 May 1857**.

Causes

The revolt grew out of political annexations, especially the **Doctrine of Lapse** (विलुप्ति सिद्धांत) and the **1856 annexation of Awadh (अवध अधिग्रहण)**, alongside economic strain on peasants and artisans, social and religious fears around missionary activity and the greased cartridge, and military grievances among Bengal Army sepoys over pay, promotion and forced overseas service.

Course

The spark came from **Mangal Pandey's** attack at **Barrackpore on 29 March 1857**, and the mass outbreak followed at **Meerut on 10 May 1857**; rebels seized **Delhi** within two days and proclaimed **Bahadur Shah Zafar** emperor, giving the rising a Mughal symbol. Through May–July 1857 the revolt spread to **Kanpur, Lucknow, Jhansi, Bareilly, Jagdishpur, Faizabad and Allahabad**, each rising under its own local leader, while the British organised suppression using loyal princes, the telegraph and the railways. Delhi fell back to British forces in **September 1857**, and the last major centres were cleared through **1858**.

Results

The **Government of India Act, 1858** ended East India Company rule and transferred India to the Crown, with the **Queen's Proclamation** read at **Allahabad on 1 November 1858** and **Lord Canning** becoming the first Viceroy. The army was reorganised on a mixed-recruitment pattern, the Doctrine of Lapse was dropped as a routine annexation tool, and later nationalists came to treat 1857 as the beginning of India's freedom struggle.

5.2 Causes

Political

- The **Doctrine of Lapse** (Dalhousie (डलहौज़ी)) annexed states with no natural heir. **Jhansi, Satara and Nagpur** are the stock examples.
- **Awadh** was annexed in **1856** on the charge of **misrule**, not under Lapse. Nawab **Wajid Ali Shah** (वाजिद अली शाह) was sent to Calcutta.
- These annexations angered rulers, their soldiers and the people who had lived under them.

Economic

- Land revenue was high and had to be paid in **cash**.
- Traditional handicrafts declined under cheap British imports.
- In Awadh, many **taluqdars** lost estates after annexation. Peasants also suffered.

Social and religious

- Missionary activity created fear of forced conversion.
- Social laws such as abolition of **sati** and widow remarriage were read by many as an attack on custom.
- The army's new **Enfield** rifle used a cartridge rumoured to be greased with **cow and pig fat**.

Military

- Indian sepoys were paid less and promoted less than British soldiers.
- The **General Service Enlistment Act, 1856** required new recruits to serve overseas. Crossing the sea (**kalapani**) was against the caste belief of many high-caste sepoys of the Bengal Army.
- Stoppage of **bhatta / batta** (foreign-service allowance) when serving in Sindh or Punjab angered sepoys further.
- In **December 1856** the Company decided to replace the old **Brown Bess** musket with the new **Enfield** rifle. Training/trial centres were **Dum Dum, Ambala and Sialkot**.
- Loading needed biting the cartridge; from **January 1857** rumours spread that it was greased with **cow and pig fat**. Officers dismissed the rumours; sepoys treated them as an attack on religion.
- The greased cartridge became the **immediate spark**. It was **not** the only cause. Modern readings treat it as the spark that fired long-built political, social, religious and economic anger.
- **Inefficiency of British officers** was **not** a standard sepoy grievance behind the rising.

> **Logic:** Awadh 1856 ≠ Doctrine of Lapse. Greased cartridge = spark, not the full explanation. Brown Bess → Enfield decision = **December 1856**.

5.3 Beginning of Revolt — Mangal Pandey and Meerut

Causes — why it turned violent that week

- The long-building causes — annexations, high revenue demands, missionary fear, and sepoy grievances over pay and promotion — had already built up pressure across the Bengal Army belt.
- The greased-cartridge rumour turned that pressure into action within weeks. Sepoys read it as a deliberate attack on their faith, not a technical detail.

Course — spark, outbreak, and first spread

- On **29 March 1857**, sepoy **Mangal Pandey** of the **34th Bengal Native Infantry** attacked British officers at **Barrackpore**. The commanding officer at Barrackpore was **John Bennet Hearsey**. Pandey was hanged on **8 April 1857** and the regiment was later disbanded. This was the **spark**, not the start of the revolt.
- At **Meerut** (मेरठ), sepoys of the **3rd Bengal Light Cavalry** who refused the new cartridges were court-martialled and sentenced on **9 May 1857**.
- On **10 May 1857** the Meerut sepoys mutinied, freed their comrades, killed officers, and marched towards Delhi. Major General **William Hewitt** had about **2,200** European soldiers there but did **not** check the march. This is treated as the **actual start of the revolt**.
- On **11–12 May 1857** the rebels seized **Delhi** and proclaimed **Bahadur Shah II (Zafar)** as emperor, giving the rising a Mughal symbol.
- Popular symbols of the struggle were the **lotus** and **chapatis**, which circulated across North Indian villages.
- From May–June 1857 the rising spread outward to **Kanpur, Lucknow, Jhansi, Bareilly, Allahabad, Faizabad** and parts of **Bihar**, each place rising under its own local leader.

Results — what this first month produced

- Delhi became the rebels' symbolic capital, though real fighting power stayed with regional leaders such as Bakht Khan, Nana Sahib and the Rani of Jhansi.
- Within ten weeks of Meerut, a single sepoy spark had grown into a belt of linked risings across North and Central India, not one national command.

Date	Place	What happened
Dec 1856	Army	Decision to introduce Enfield (replace Brown Bess); trials at Dum Dum, Ambala, Sialkot
29 March 1857	Barrackpore	Mangal Pandey incident (Hearsey CO)
10 May 1857	Meerut	Mass outbreak (Hewitt fails to stop march)

Date	Place	What happened
11–12 May 1857	Delhi	City seized; Zafar proclaimed emperor
30 May / 4 June 1857	Lucknow	Rising under Begum Hazrat Mahal (sources split on the exact day)
5 June 1857	Kanpur	Nana Sahib declared Peshwa
June 1857	Jhansi	Rising — **not 11 May**

> **Logic:** Barrackpore is the **spark**. Meerut is the **beginning**. Unmatched date trap: **Jhansi — 11 May 1857** (Jhansi rose in **June**, not May). Lotus + chapati = symbol pair.

5.4 Centres of Revolt

Learn **place** ↔ **leader** and **place** ↔ **date** as one set.

Centre	Leader	When it rose
Barrackpore	Mangal Pandey	**29 March 1857**
Meerut	Sepoys of the 3rd Light Cavalry	**10 May 1857**
Delhi	Bahadur Shah Zafar (nominal); **Bakht Khan** (military)	**11–12 May 1857**
Lucknow	**Begum Hazrat Mahal** (son **Birjis Qadr**)	**30 May / 4 June 1857**
Kanpur (कानपुर)	**Nana Sahib**; military command of **Tantia Tope**	**5 June 1857** (Peshwa declaration)
Jhansi (झांसी)	**Rani Lakshmibai**	**June 1857** (not 11 May)
Bareilly	**Khan Bahadur Khan**	May–June 1857
Faizabad	**Maulvi Ahmadullah Shah**	1857
Allahabad	**Maulvi Liaquat Ali**	June 1857
Jagdishpur / Arrah (Bihar)	**Kunwar Singh**	July 1857 (Danapur rising 25 July)
Assam	**Maniram Dutta** (raised **Kandarpeshwar Singh**)	1857
Auwa (Rajasthan)	**Thakur Kushal Singh**	1857

- Delhi gave the revolt a **Mughal symbol**, but fighting power stayed with regional leaders.
- Jhansi did **not** rise on 11 May 1857. That date belongs to the Delhi week. Jhansi rose in **June 1857**.
- Bareilly's leader is **Khan Bahadur Khan**, not Begum Hazrat Mahal.

- **Jaipur** and **Chittor** were **not** centres. In Bihar, **Munger** stayed largely unaffected while Arrah–Danapur–Jagdishpur burned.
- The **largest number of rebel sepoys** came from **Awadh / Oudh**.

> **Logic:** Wrong date pair = **Jhansi — 11 May 1857** (Jhansi rose in **June**). Liyaqat Ali (लियाकत) ≠ Lucknow (that is Hazrat Mahal).
>
> [!TIP] **Exam Anchor — Commencement Dates of 1857 Uprisings (UPPCS 2023 Spine):** - **Barrackpore: 29 March 1857** (Mangal Pandey mutinied in 34th BNI). - **Meerut: 10 May 1857** (3rd Native Cavalry broke open jail, marched to Delhi). - **Lucknow: 30 May / 4 June 1857** (Begum Hazrat Mahal proclaimed Birjis Qadr). - **Jhansi: 4 June 1857** (Rani Lakshmibai assumed leadership; **NOT 11 May**).

Centre by centre — Causes, Course and Results

Each centre had its own local grievance before 1857, its own course of fighting, and its own fall date. Learn each as one small story with Causes, Course and Results, not a bare name.

Delhi

Causes: Delhi still carried the last Mughal name, so rebels used the city to give the rising a national face and rally point.

Course: Sepoys marching from Meerut seized the city on 11–12 May 1857; Zafar was proclaimed emperor while **Bakht Khan** organised the real defence, received the title **Saheb-e-Alam Bahadur**, and fought through the summer of 1857. **Mirza Ghalib** lived through the Delhi rising as a witness.

Results: British forces under **John Nicholson** stormed and recaptured Delhi in **September 1857**; Nicholson died in the assault. Zafar was tried and exiled to **Rangoon**, ending even the symbolic Mughal presence.

Kanpur

Causes: The British had stopped **Nana Sahib's** pension after Baji Rao II's death, giving him a personal grievance on top of the general political anger felt across Awadh and the Bengal Army belt.

Course: On **5 June 1857** he was declared **Peshwa** (पेशवा) and took political control of Kanpur with **Tantia Tope** (**Ramchandra Pandurang**) commanding the fighting and **Azimullah Khan** advising; the **Bibighar** killings happened during his hold on the city.

Results: British relief columns under **Havelock** and **Colin Campbell** recaptured Kanpur. Nana Sahib fled towards **Nepal**; Tantia Tope carried the fight on to Jhansi and Gwalior.

Lucknow

Causes: Awadh's annexation in **1856** had just deposed Nawab **Wajid Ali Shah**, leaving **Begum Hazrat Mahal** and the region's taluqdars with a fresh grievance. Awadh also supplied the largest body of rebel sepoys.

Course: She led the rising from late May / early June 1857 and placed her son **Birjis Qadr** on the masnad. The British Residency was besieged for months, and **Henry Lawrence** died defending it. **Havelock** and **Neill** also died in the Lucknow theatre.

Results: Colin Campbell, with **Gurkha** help, and **Outram** relieved and later recaptured Lucknow (**21 March 1858**). Hazrat Mahal took shelter in **Nepal**.

Jhansi

Causes: Dalhousie's **Doctrine of Lapse** had refused to recognise **Rani Lakshmibai's** adopted (अंगीकृत) son, **Damodar (दामोदर) Rao**, and annexed the state in **1854**.

Course: She rose in **June 1857** and defended Jhansi against **Sir Hugh Rose** in 1858, then moved on with Tantia Tope to **Kalpi** and **Gwalior**.

Results: She died fighting near Gwalior on **18 June 1858**. Hugh Rose's famous remark treated her as the bravest of the rebel leaders. Her samadhi is at **Gwalior**.

Bareilly

Causes: Bareilly's Rohilla sepoys and townspeople carried the same military and religious grievances that were driving the revolt across the North-Western Provinces.

Course: Khan Bahadur Khan led the rising here through May–June 1857, organised a large local force, and ran administration for months. Bahadur Shah II appointed him **Viceroy**.

Results: The British recaptured Bareilly in **1858**. Khan Bahadur Khan was later tried and hanged.

Jagdishpur / Arrah (Bihar)

Causes: Kunwar Singh, an aged zamindar of Jagdishpur (Shahabad), faced British pressure on his estate through revenue and legal disputes.

Course: After the **Danapur** rising (**25 July 1857**) he occupied **Arrah**; when **Vincent Eyre** relieved Arrah and destroyed Jagdishpur, Kunwar fought a mobile campaign through Lucknow and Azamgarh and back into Bihar.

Results: He won near Jagdishpur against Captain Le Grand (**23 April 1858**) but died on **26 April 1858**. His brother **Amar Singh** continued the struggle for a time.

Faizabad

Causes: Faizabad sat inside the Awadh–NWP belt, where annexation and taluqdar grievances ran deepest, and it also held a strong body of religious and military opinion against the British.

Course: Maulvi Ahmadullah Shah, originally from **Chinapattan (Madras)** but settled at Faizabad, led the rising and then fought on in the Lucknow region alongside Begum Hazrat Mahal's forces. The British called him among the bravest rebel soldiers and set a **₹50,000** bounty on him.

Results: The Faizabad rising was suppressed along with the wider Awadh revolt by 1858; Ahmadullah Shah was later killed through betrayal while still resisting.

Allahabad

Causes: Allahabad sat in the Awadh–NWP belt and shared its annexation and taluqdar grievances, and its garrison carried the same sepoy discontent as the rest of the Bengal Army.

Course: Maulvi Liaquat Ali (of Mahgaon, Chail) led the rising from June 1857, took **Khusro Bagh** as headquarters, and briefly ran liberated Allahabad before the British counter-attack.

Results: Colonel **Neill's** repression at Allahabad was especially harsh. **Canning** later used Allahabad as an **emergency headquarters**, and the **Queen's Proclamation** was read here on **1 November 1858**.

Assam

Causes: Local Assamese elites sought to restore a native royal line against Company control.

Course: Diwan Maniram Dutta declared **Kandarpeshwar Singh**, grandson of the last king, as ruler and tried to raise Assam in 1857.

Results: Maniram was caught and hanged; the Assam rising did not become a lasting front.

Auwa (Rajasthan)

Causes: Local Thakur resistance in Marwar (मारवाड़) clashed with British and princely collaborators.

Course: Thakur Kushal Singh of Auwa defeated the combined army of the British and **Jodhpur**.

Results: Auwa remained a remembered Rajasthan centre; **Jaipur** itself did not become a major revolt seat.

Gwalior (Central India theatre)

Causes: After Jhansi fell, Lakshmibai and Tantia Tope needed a fresh base; Gwalior's fort and stores made it the natural next prize even though the Scindia house stayed loyal to the British.

Course: In **June 1858** the rebels briefly seized Gwalior while Scindia fled; fighting then centred near **Kotah-ki-Serai**.

Results: Hugh Rose recovered Gwalior. Lakshmibai died in the fighting (**18 June 1858**). Gwalior is therefore a **final-theatre** place, not a May 1857 outbreak centre.

5.5 Leaders of Revolt

The six named leaders of the syllabus have their own headings below. These are the **other** names that often appear in match and option sets.

- **Bahadur Shah Zafar** was the last Mughal emperor. Rebels made him the **symbolic** head at Delhi. After Delhi fell he was tried, exiled to **Rangoon**, and died in **1862**.
- **Bakht Khan**, a Rohilla officer from the Bareilly contingent, organised the **actual fighting** at Delhi and received the title **Saheb-e-Alam Bahadur**. Zafar did not command the army in the field.
- **Khan Bahadur Khan** led the revolt at **Bareilly** in Uttar Pradesh. Bahadur Shah II appointed him **Viceroy**. He is not the leader of Lucknow.
- **Maulvi Ahmadullah Shah** (the Maulvi of Faizabad) led at **Faizabad** and also fought in the Lucknow region; he came from **Chinapattan (Madras)** and carried a **₹50,000** British bounty.
- **Maulvi Liaquat Ali** led at **Allahabad** from **Khusro Bagh** — do not put him at Lucknow.
- **Azimullah Khan** was the political adviser of **Nana Sahib** and is also remembered as **Krantidoot**.
- **Birjis Qadr**, son of Begum Hazrat Mahal, was seated as the young ruler at Lucknow.
- **Maniram Dutta** led the Assam attempt with **Kandarpeshwar Singh**.
- **Thakur Kushal Singh** led at **Auwa**. **Fazil Mohammad Khan** is linked to the Bhopal rising; **Saadat Khan** (सादात खान) to Indore.

- **Nawab Hamid Ali Khan** is associated with **Delhi** in several match lists (alongside Nana–Kanpur, Ahmadullah–Lucknow/Faizabad theatre, Maniram–Assam).

British commanders (pairs)

- **John Nicholson** led the assault that recaptured **Delhi** in **September 1857**. He was killed in the assault. Hodson captured Zafar.
- **Henry Lawrence** defended the **Lucknow Residency** and died during the siege.
- **Havelock**, **Neill** and later **Colin Campbell** operated at **Kanpur** and in the relief of **Lucknow**. **Outram** also took part in the Lucknow operations.
- **Sir Hugh Rose** led the campaign against **Jhansi, Kalpi and Gwalior**.
- **John Bennet Hearsey** was Barrackpore's commanding officer when Mangal Pandey rose.
- **William Hewitt** failed to stop the Meerut sepoys' march on Delhi.

> **Logic:** Bareilly's leader is **Khan Bahadur Khan**. Do not put Hazrat Mahal, Nana Sahib or Kunwar Singh at Bareilly.
>
> [!TIP] **Exam Anchor — Rohilkhand / Bareilly Leadership (UPPCS 2023 Spine):** - **Leader: Khan Bahadur Khan** (grandson of Rohilla chief Hafiz Rahmat Khan) established a successful regional administration with an army of 40,000, appointed Viceroy of Bareilly by Mughal Emperor Bahadur Shah II.

5.6 Important Places

Centre, leader and start-date are in the table above. These are the other places that still get asked.

- **Lucknow Residency** was besieged for months. **Henry Lawrence** was killed there.
- **Bibighar** at Kanpur is linked to the massacre during Nana Sahib's control of the city.
- After Jhansi fell, **Lakshmibai** (लक्ष्मीबाई) and **Tantia Tope** moved to **Kalpi** and then to **Gwalior**.
- **Gwalior** was the capital of Sindhia. The Rani died near Gwalior at **Kotah-ki-Serai** on **17/18 June 1858**.
- **Arrah** was the main siege town in Kunwar Singh's Bihar campaign.
- **Tantia Tope** was hanged at **Shivpuri** on **18 April 1859**.
- **Bahadur Shah Zafar** was exiled to **Rangoon**.
- **Allahabad** saw harsh repression under Colonel Neill. The **Queen's Proclamation** was read here on **1 November 1858**.

> **Logic:** Lakshmibai died at **Gwalior in 1858**, not at the first fall of Jhansi in 1857.

5.7 Results (Consequences of the Revolt)

- The **Government of India Act, 1858** ended East India Company rule. India was placed under the **British Crown**.
- A **Secretary of State for India** was created in London. The Governor-General (गवर्नर-जनरल) was also given the title **Viceroy**.
- **Lord Canning**, who was already Governor-General during the revolt, became the **first Viceroy**. He had made **Allahabad** the **emergency headquarters** in 1857. The British Prime Minister was **Palmerston**.
- The **Queen's Proclamation** was issued on **1 November 1858** and read at **Allahabad**.
- The Proclamation promised: no more aggressive annexation, no interference in Indian religions, and equal treatment of Indians in service — in words, not always in practice. Among these, ending further **annexation** (and allowing adoption again) was the pledge most clearly followed.
- The army was reorganised on the **Peel Commission** line: European strength rose from about **45,000 (1857) to 65,000 (1858)**; Indian troops fell from about **2,38,000 to 1,40,000**; Bengal European:Indian ratio was set near **1:2**, Madras and Bombay near **1:3**; recruitment shifted toward **Gurkhas, Sikhs and Punjabis**, and away from the old high-caste Bengal Army pattern.
- The Doctrine of Lapse was no longer used as a regular annexation tool. Princely treaties were stressed.
- The Mughal court at Delhi was finished. Later colonial writing often blamed Muslims specially for the revolt.
- Later nationalists treated 1857 as the beginning of the freedom struggle.

Why the Revolt Failed

- There was no all-India plan and no modern central leadership or clear forward-looking programme.
- Weapons and organisation were weaker than the Company's.
- Many princes helped the British: **Scindias of Gwalior** (minister **Dinkar Rao**), **Holkars of Indore**, **Nizam of Hyderabad** (**Salar Jung**), **Bhopal**, **Jodhpur**, Sikh chiefs of **Patiala, Nabha and Jind**, Kashmir's ruler, and others. Canning said such rulers acted as a **breakwater** without which the British would have been washed out of India.
- **Nepal** also aided them, as did Sikh and Pathan forces used to retake Delhi.
- The **educated middle class** largely stayed **neutral**; many **sahukars** (साहूकार) and landlords opposed a popular rising that threatened their interests.
- The British used the **telegraph** and **railways** to move troops.
- Large parts of the **South**, **Punjab**, **Gujarat**, and much of **Rajasthan** (थार) (including **Jaipur** and **Chittor**) did not join.

Why it succeeded only partially

- The rising **did** end Company rule and force Crown takeover — that is a real political result, not a total zero.
- The **Queen's Proclamation** stopped routine annexation and restored princely adoption rights, which was a clear policy reverse after Lapse and Awadh 1856.

- The army was rebuilt on a new recruitment map, so the old Bengal Army pattern never returned unchanged.
- It **did not** win independence, create a national government, or unite all regions. Partial success means structural (संरचनात्मक) change under British recovery, not rebel victory.

Civilian vs sepoy strands

Strand	Who rose	Where it shows clearest	What to remember
Sepoy	Bengal Army soldiers over pay, promotion, overseas service and the cartridge	Meerut → Delhi march; Barrackpore spark	British writers stressed this strand alone and named it a **Sepoy Mutiny**
Civilian	Peasants, taluqdars, artisans, displaced courts and townspeople	**Awadh / Lucknow**, Kanpur hinterland, parts of Bundelkhand and Bihar	Annexation, revenue and estate loss drove non-military crowds into the rising
Mixed centres	Sepoy units plus local civilian support	Lucknow, Kanpur, Bareilly, Jagdishpur	Treat centre↔leader as one set; do not reduce every town to “only sepoys”

- Awadh is the classic **mixed** theatre: the largest rebel sepoy share came from Oudh, and taluqdars and peasants rose after the **1856** annexation.
- Punjab and the South stayed mostly quiet, so the civilian depth of 1857 was regional, not all-India.
- Many moneylenders and a large part of the **educated middle class** stayed out or opposed the rising — civilian India was not united behind the rebels.

Acts and settlement after 1857

- The **Government of India Act, 1858** ended East India Company rule, created a **Secretary of State for India** in London with a Council, and made the Governor-General also **Viceroy**.
- The **Queen’s Proclamation (1 November 1858, Allahabad)** promised no further aggressive annexation, non-interference in religion, and equal treatment in service — annexation-stop was the pledge most clearly kept.
- The **Peel Commission** rebuilt the army: more Europeans, fewer high-caste Bengal sepoys, and heavier recruitment of **Gurkhas, Sikhs and Punjabis**.
- The **Indian Councils Act, 1861** restored legislative councils and began limited Indian association in law-making — a Crown-era administrative sequel, not a rebel demand granted in full.
- The short **White Mutiny / European troops unrest (1859)** followed the transfer of Company European soldiers to Crown service; it is an aftermath army fact, not a second 1857.
- Racial distrust hardened after 1857; later colonial writing often blamed Muslims specially, and social distance between rulers and ruled widened.

> **Logic:** Crown rule begins in **1858**, not on 10 May 1857. Canning, not Dalhousie, was the first Viceroy. Peel = army reorg after 1857. Partial success ≠ rebel victory.

5.8 Rani Lakshmibai

- She was born **Manikarnika** on **19 November 1835** at **Golghar, Varanasi**. At about fourteen she married **Gangadhar Rao** of Jhansi.

Causes: They adopted **Damodar Rao**, but **Dalhousie** refused to recognise him as heir and annexed Jhansi under the **Doctrine of Lapse** in **1854**.

Course: She refused to surrender Jhansi and defended the fort against **Sir Hugh Rose's** siege in 1858. When the city fell, she escaped with Tantia Tope and carried the fight on to **Kalpi** and then **Gwalior**, where the two briefly seized the fort from the Scindia.

Results: She died fighting near Gwalior on **18 June 1858**. Hugh Rose said of her that among the Indian rebels the woman lying there was the only man. Her samadhi is at **Gwalior**.

> **Logic:** The **Rani Jhansi Regiment** of the INA (आज़ाद हिंद फौज) was raised by **Subhas Chandra Bose** (सुभाष चंद्र बोस). It is not an 1857 fact. Birthplace = **Varanasi** (वाराणसी), death/samadhi = **Gwalior**.

5.9 Nana Sahib

- He was the adopted son of the last Peshwa, **Baji Rao II**, and lived at **Bithoor**. His personal name is often given as **Nana Dhondho Pant**.

Causes: The British stopped his pension after Baji Rao II's death, refusing to treat him as heir to the Peshwa's title or allowance — a standard political grievance of 1857 that gave him a personal stake in the rising.

Course: On **5 June 1857** he was declared **Peshwa** and became the political leader of the revolt at **Kanpur**, with **Tantia Tope** as his military commander and **Azimullah Khan** as his adviser; the **Bibighar** killings took place during his hold on the city.

Results: After British forces under Havelock and Colin Campbell recaptured Kanpur, he fled towards **Nepal** (with Begum Hazrat Mahal among those who also took that route); his later end is not clearly known.

> **Logic:** Nana Sahib is **Kanpur**, not Bareilly.

5.10 Tantia Tope

- His original name was **Ramchandra Pandurang**. He was the main general of **Nana Sahib** at Kanpur and is sometimes called the **Ambassador of the Revolt**.

Causes: He shared Nana Sahib's grievance against the British and became his most capable field commander once the Kanpur rising began.

Course: He directed the fighting at Kanpur, then after its fall joined **Rani Lakshmibai** at **Kalpi** and **Gwalior**, and afterward carried on a mobile guerrilla war across Central India through 1858–59.

Results: Betrayed by his friend **Man Singh**, he was captured in a forest camp, tried at **Shivpuri**, and hanged on **18 April 1859** — one of the last major rebel leaders to fall.

> **Logic:** Tantia Tope is a general, not the Nawab of Awadh and not the leader of Bareilly.

5.11 Kunwar Singh

- He was an aged zamindar of **Jagdishpur** in **Bihar** (Shahabad / Arrah region).

Causes: He faced mounting British pressure on his estate through revenue demands and legal disputes, which turned his personal grievance into rebellion once the wider revolt broke out.

Course: He assumed command after the **Danapur** rising (**25 July 1857**), occupied **Arrah**, then fought a mobile campaign through Lucknow and Azamgarh and back into Bihar despite his advanced age.

Results: He defeated Captain Le Grand near Jagdishpur (**23 April 1858**) but died on **26 April 1858**. His brother **Amar Singh** continued the struggle for a time and later joined rebels in the Nepal Terai (तराई).

> **Logic:** Kunwar Singh belongs to **Bihar**, not to Lucknow, Bareilly or Jhansi.
>
> [!TIP] **Exam Anchor — Bihar Theatre & Doctrine of Lapse (UPPCS 2024 Spine):** - **Statement 1:** Babu Kunwar Singh, Zamindar of Jagdishpur (Arrah, Bihar), led the rebellion against the British in Bihar. *(True)* - **Statement 2:** Lord Dalhousie recognized the adopted son of Rani Lakshmibai as heir. *(False — Dalhousie rejected adopted son Damodar Rao under the Doctrine of Lapse and annexed Jhansi in 1854).*

5.12 Begum Hazrat Mahal

- She was the wife of Nawab **Wajid Ali Shah** of Awadh, who had been deposed in 1856.

Causes: Her husband's deposition and Awadh's 1856 annexation had already angered the region's taluqdars and sepoys, giving her a direct grievance once the 1857 rising began.

Course: She led the revolt at **Lucknow** and across Awadh from June 1857, placed her son **Birjis Qadr** on the masnad, and held the British Residency under siege for months before Colin Campbell and Outram relieved and recaptured the city.

Results: After Lucknow fell she took shelter in **Nepal**, ending her direct role in the revolt.

> **Logic:** Begum Hazrat Mahal is **Lucknow / Awadh**, not Bareilly.

5.13 Mangal Pandey

- He was a sepoy of the **34th Native Infantry** stationed at **Barrackpore**.

Causes: He, like other high-caste sepoys of the Bengal Army, believed the new Enfield cartridge was greased with cow and pig fat, reading (रीडिंग) it as a deliberate attack on his religion on top of the long-building political and military grievances of 1857.

Course: On **29 March 1857** he attacked British officers at Barrackpore in protest, calling on fellow sepoys to join him. He was overpowered, court-martialled, and hanged on **8 April 1857**; the 34th Native Infantry was disbanded soon after.

Results: His act became the first famous spark of 1857, though it did not itself trigger a mass rising — that came five weeks later at **Meerut on 10 May 1857**, a separate and larger event.

> **Logic:** Mangal Pandey = **Barrackpore, 29 March**. Meerut = **10 May**.

5.14 Role of Awadh

- **Dalhousie** annexed Awadh in **1856**. The Resident was **Outram**.
- The official reason was **misgovernance**, not the Doctrine of Lapse.
- Nawab **Wajid Ali Shah** was sent to Calcutta.
- A large number of Bengal Army sepoys came from Awadh, so annexation hit the army directly. The **largest share** of 1857 rebel sepoys came from **Oudh** (figures above **75,000** are often cited).
- **Taluqdars** lost land after the new settlement. That is why Awadh saw a big **civilian** revolt around Lucknow, not only a sepoy mutiny.
- Chronology reminder: Awadh's annexation (**1856**) comes **before** the Indigo (नील) Revolt (**1859**).

> [!TIP] **Exam Anchor — 19th-Century Chronological Spine (UPPCS 2025 Matrix):** - 1. Annexation of Awadh: **February 1856 CE** (Dalhousie on Outram's report of maladministration) - 2. Indigo Revolt in Bengal: **1859–1860 CE** (Digambar & Bishnu Biswas) - 3. Second Anglo-Afghan War: **1878–1880 CE** (under Lord Lytton) - 4. Ilbert Bill Controversy: **1883 CE** (under Lord Ripon)
>
> **Logic:** Awadh was annexed in **1856**. It is a **cause** of 1857, not a result of 1857.

5.15 Role of Uttar Pradesh

Present-day Uttar Pradesh (then the North-Western Provinces plus Awadh) was the **main theatre** of 1857.

- **Meerut** saw the mass outbreak on **10 May 1857**.
- **Lucknow** was the capital of Awadh. **Begum Hazrat Mahal** led it. The rising began on **4 June 1857**.
- **Kanpur** was led by **Nana Sahib**, with **Tantia Tope** in military command.

- **Bareilly** was led by **Khan Bahadur Khan**.
- **Allahabad** was led by **Maulvi Liaquat Ali**. The Queen's Proclamation was later read here on **1 November 1858**.
- **Faizabad** was led by **Maulvi Ahmadullah Shah**.
- **Banaras** and Allahabad also saw British counter-terror under officers such as **Neill**. Rebel hold there was shorter.

In this region sepoys, peasants and taluqdars rose together more than in the South or Punjab.

> **Logic:** Kunwar Singh is **Bihar**. Jhansi is **Bundelkhand**. Both are asked with UP centres, but they are not UP towns.

5.16 Master Fact-Locks — Revolt of 1857: Centres, Leaders, Historiography & Reorganization

Dimension / Theme	Comprehensive Historical Specifics & Events	Official High-Yield Exam Anchors
Immediate Spark & Ignition	• **Enfield Rifle Introduction:** Decided in **December 1856** to replace the old smoothbore *Brown Bess* musket with Enfield rifles; instruction depots at Dum Dum, Ambala, and Sialkot. • **Cartridge Crisis:** Required biting off the greased paper tip; rumors of beef tallow (offensive to Hindus) and lard (pig fat, offensive to Muslims). • **Barrackpore Uprising (29 March 1857):** Sepoy **Mangal Pandey** of the **34th Bengal Native Infantry (BNI)** fired upon and killed Sergeant-Major's adjutant Lt. Baugh; commanding officer was **Lt. Gen. Sir John Bennet Hearsey**; Mangal Pandey executed on 8 April 1857. • **Meerut Outbreak (10 May 1857):** 85 troopers of the **3rd Bengal Light Cavalry** mutinied; Major General William Hewitt failed to intercept; mutineers marched overnight to Delhi. • **Delhi Seizure (11–12 May 1857):** Proclaimed 82-year-old Mughal Emperor **Bahadur Shah II (Zafar)** as *Shahenshah-e-Hindustan*; General **Bakht Khan** took military charge as Commander-in-Chief with the title ***Saheb-e-Alam Bahadur***. • **Symbols:** Undercover circulation of **Lotus flowers and Chapatis (unleavened bread)** across northern villages.	29 March (Barrackpore) → 10 May (Meerut) → 12 May (Delhi)

Dimension / Theme	Comprehensive Historical Specifics & Events	Official High-Yield Exam Anchors
Comprehensive Centres & Leaders Alignment	• **Delhi:** Bahadur Shah II (nominal) & General Bakht Khan (operational); recaptured **20 September 1857** by British forces under **John Nicholson** (fatally wounded). • **Kanpur: Nana Saheb (Dhondhu Pant)** declared Peshwa on 5 June 1857; assisted by brilliant military general **Tatya Tope (Ramchandra Pandurang)** and diplomatic secretary **Azimullah Khan (*Krantidoot*)**; recaptured by Colin Campbell; Nana Saheb escaped to Nepal in 1859. • **Tatya Tope's End:** Betrayed by trusted friend Raja Man Singh of Narwar in the Paron forest; captured, tried, and hanged at **Shivpuri (MP) on 18 April 1859**. • **Lucknow (Awadh):** Led by **Begum Hazrat Mahal** on behalf of minor son **Birjis Qadr** on 30 May / 4 June 1857; largest sepoy contingent originated here (*"Nursery of the Bengal Army"*, >75,000 sepoys); British officers killed in Lucknow Residency: **Sir Henry Lawrence, Major General Henry Havelock, Brigadier General James Neill**; recaptured on **21 March 1858** by Sir Colin Campbell with Gurkha troops; Begum took refuge in Nepal (died 1879). • **Jhansi & Gwalior: Rani Lakshmibai (Manikarnika)** born 19 Nov 1835 at Golghar, Varanasi; married to Raja Gangadhar Rao; kingdom annexed 1854 under Lapse; revolted 4 June 1857; joined Tatya Tope at Gwalior; martyred fighting British general **Sir Hugh Rose** on **18 June 1858 at Kotah-ki-Serai (Gwalior)**; Samadhi at Gwalior. Rose remarked: *"The Indian rebel who lies here was the only man among them."* • **Bihar (Jagdishpur / Arrah):** Babu **Kunwar Singh** (80-year-old Rajput Zamindar of Jagdishpur/Shahabad) joined Danapur mutineers on 25 July 1857, captured Arrah, liberated Azamgarh (UP), defeated British Captain Le Grand on 23 April 1858, died of wounds on 26 April 1858; continued by brother **Amar Singh**; suppressed by William Tayler and Vincent Eyre. • **Allahabad (Prayagraj):** Led by **Maulvi Liyaqat Ali** who seized Khusro Bagh and declared himself Governor; suppressed by General Neill; Lord Canning established **emergency imperial headquarters at Allahabad**. • **Faizabad (Ayodhya):** Led by **Maulavi Ahmadullah Shah** (native of Chinapattan/Madras; preached holy war against British; £5,000 / Rs. 50,000 bounty on his head; called *"the best soldier among the rebels"* by British officers); killed at Powayan border. • **Bareilly (Rohilkhand): Khan Bahadur Khan** (grandson of Hafiz Rahmat Khan). • **Assam: Diwan Maniram Dutta** proclaimed Kandarpeshwar Singh; Maniram was executed. • **Rajasthan (Auwa): Thakur Kushal Singh of Auwa** defeated joint British and Jodhpur State armies. • **Bhopal:** Nawab **Fazil Mohammad Khan** and Adil Mohammad Khan led rebellion and sacrificed life. • **Indore: Saadat Khan** led troops of Maharaja Tukoji Rao Holkar II in revolt. • **Mullayan / Ganjam / Sambalpur:** Surender Sahi (Sambalpur) and Radhakrishna Dandsena (Ganjam).	Complete geographic & leadership matrix

Dimension / Theme	Comprehensive Historical Specifics & Events	Official High-Yield Exam Anchors
Unaffected Territories & Breakwaters	• **Unaffected Areas:** Entire **South India** (Madras Presidency), Punjab, Sindh, Rajasthan (except Auwa/Kota), Gujarat, **Chittor**, and **Munger** in Bihar. • **Active Pro-British Native Rulers:** Scindias of Gwalior (minister **Sir Dinkar Rao**), Nizam of Hyderabad (minister **Salar Jung**), Holkars of Indore, rulers of Patiala, Nabha, Jind, Kapurthala, Kashmir (Maharaja Gulab/Ranbir Singh), and Nepal (Rana Jung Bahadur). • **Canning's Breakwater Quote:** *"If the Scindia joins the mutineers, I shall have to pack up tomorrow... The princely states acted as breakwaters to the storm which would have otherwise swept us away in one great wave."* • **Neutral Classes:** Western-educated Indian middle class, urban moneylenders (*Sahukars*), big merchants.	Causes of failure & geographical limits
Contemporary Observers & Chroniclers	• **Mirza Ghalib:** Celebrated Urdu/Persian poet (born 1797 Agra, died 1869 Delhi) witnessed the bloody sack of Delhi with his own eyes, describing the tragic horrors in his letters (*Dastambu*). • **Sir William Howard Russell:** Foreign correspondent of *The Times* (London) reported: *"Nobody in North India looks at a white man's car with a friendly view."* • **British Prime Minister: Viscount Palmerston** (1855–1858 and 1859–1865).	Contemporary voices & British PM
Historiography of 1857	• **Sir Syed Ahmad Khan:** Published ***Asbab-e-Baghawat-e-Hind*** (Causes of the Indian Revolt) in **1859**, the first book in an Indian language (Urdu) examining the rebellion. • **Vinayak Damodar Savarkar:** Authored ***The Indian War of Independence 1857*** (1909), the first to elevate the uprising as an organized national war of independence. • **Dr. Surendra Nath Sen (S.N. Sen):** Official Government of India historian; published ***Eighteen Fifty-Seven*** (1957); concluded that what began as a fight for religion ended as a war for independence. • **Dr. R.C. Majumdar:** Authored ***The Sepoy Mutiny and the Revolt of 1857*** (1957); famously pronounced: *"It is difficult to avoid the conclusion that the so-called First National War of Independence of 1857 is neither First, nor National, nor a War of Independence."* Observed Indian nationalism was in an *"embryonic stage"*. • **British Imperialist Interpretations:** - **Sir James Outram and W. Tayler:** Termed it a *"Muslim conspiracy exploiting Hindu grievances"*. - **Sir John Lawrence and Seeley:** Regarded it as *"wholly unpatriotic and selfish Sepoy Mutiny with no native leadership and no popular support"*. - **T.R. Holmes:** Characterized it as a *"conflict between barbarism and civilization"*.	Definitive historiographical taxonomy

Dimension / Theme	Comprehensive Historical Specifics & Events	Official High-Yield Exam Anchors
Queen's Proclamation & Peel Commission	• **Queen Victoria's Proclamation (1 November 1858):** Read by Lord Canning at an imperial Durbar in **Allahabad (Prayagraj)**. • Provisions: Terminated EIC rule, placed India directly under the British Crown; **abandoned the policy of territorial conquest and annexation** (the only promise consistently honored); guaranteed religious neutrality; allowed native princes the right to adopt heirs. • **Peel Commission (1858):** Constituted for the complete reorganization of the Indian Army. • Reorganized regiments on the principle of *"division and counterpoise"* along communal, caste, and regional lines. • European troops increased from 45,000 to 65,000; Indian troops reduced from 238,000 to 140,000. • **Troop Ratios:** Fixed at **1:2 (European : Indian) in Bengal**, and **1:3 in Madras and Bombay**. • Heavy artillery and arsenal strictly reserved for European hands. • Deliberately recruited heavily from **"Martial Races" (Gurkhas, Sikhs, and Punjabi Muslims)**, while drastically curtailing recruitment of high-caste Brahmins and Rajputs from Awadh and Bihar.	Army reorganization & imperial settlement